MOVIES ▼

Resilience On Reel

Two female filmmakers, NAMYA CHADHA AND BOBBY SARMA BARUAH, on their films that deal with disability, freedom and identity

The first time Namya Chadha, a filmmaker and photographer from Meerut, wore a hearing aid, she was startled. As someone who is hard of hearing, the 24-year-old grew up 'caught between worlds—neither fully deaf nor fully abled'. "People assume hearing disability means deafness, but it varies from person to person," she explains. This is what Chadha explores in her documentary *Behind the Ears*.

Chadha's graduation project at NID had its international premiere at the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne in August 2025. Also sharing space was Assamese filmmaker Bobby Sarma Baruah's feature *Rador Pakhi* (Morning Sunshine), an inspiring story of overcoming disability. "The film is loosely based on the life of Assamese author Sarmistha Pritam, who has been bedridden since the age of eight because of spinal muscular atrophy. Yet she has achieved so much," says Baruah, who won a national film award for her film *Mishing* (2018).

In the year it took for Chadha to make her film, she had to learn to let go of control as a filmmaker. "In films, the director tells you what to shoot. In a participatory documentary, the space allows participants to share aspects of their lives and express their own perspectives." For Baruah, the challenges were no different from those of most independent directors. "If you look at the credits, you'd notice that I've done everything from research to production design and make-up. That's just how indie films get made." ■

—Karishma Upadhyay



RAPPER ▼

SOUTHERN SOUND

Rapper Iykki Berry is winning hearts with her vibrant personality and sharp performances



The 34-year-old rapper has impressed all with her unfiltered authenticity

Dr Iykki Berry is not your typical rapper. A trained medical doctor, singer, songwriter and cultural force, she has emerged as a unique voice in the independent music scene. The "Rap Queen" of Tamil Nadu has risen from Thanjavur to international stages.

After earning her MBBS, Berry established her aesthetic clinic, Berry Glow, in Chennai. But music was in her bones. "Medicine taught me discipline, empathy and the art of listening. Music taught me freedom, truth and the courage to speak," she reflects. "As a doctor, I've seen human vulnerability up close—and as a rapper, I turn that into strength in my lyrics."

Her latest track, 'Itihasam', is a genre-blending anthem that fuses Tamil literature with hip-hop. Created in collaboration with A.R. Rahman's Unreal Engine VR studio, it stands as both homage and revolution. "Hip-hop isn't just beats and bars—it's storytelling," says Berry. "In 'Itihasam', I pulled from the rich heritage of Tamil literature. Hip-hop allows me to make it breathe in today's world."

Berry's growing influence has been amplified through television appearances on *Bigg Boss Season 5*, *BB Jodigal* and *Super Singer*, where her personality, unfiltered authenticity and sharp performances have won hearts. Her style, infused with a global accent she calls "Iykkish", reflects her broad musical influences.

As she prepares to perform at Chennai's Hunterhood Festival this September, Berry speaks of her deep connection to the city. "Hunterhood is a celebration of freedom, identity and self-expression," she says. "I grew up riding on my dad's Royal Enfield Bullet, feeling that mix of power and pride. So, when I perform here, it's about bringing that same energy into my music." ■

—Nikhil Sardana